

African Voices on *Ochorus*

Progress Report & Recommendations

Growing Ochorus's African authorship — the bios, books and sermons of African and African-diaspora authors — within its public-domain constraint.

Five African-authored books, and Ochorus's first sub-Saharan voice.

This initiative adds African and African-diaspora authors — their bios, books and sermons — to Ochorus, and deepens those already present. Ochorus is **public-domain only**, and that single constraint shapes every choice below.

Since it began, **five African-authored books have shipped** — three of them built in this push. Together they gave Ochorus its first sub-Saharan African book and completed a cluster of early Black women preachers, a seam of vivid nineteenth-century spiritual memoir that now reads as a chorus rather than a single voice.

The chief lesson of the work so far is a practical one about where effort goes. It is not the writing or the import that is expensive — it is the state of the source text.

THE LESSON THAT GOVERNS EVERY ESTIMATE

Source cleanliness governs effort. Clean transcriptions — CCEL, Project Gutenberg, DocSouth — import in about an hour. Internet Archive OCR scans cost **hours of per-book text repair** (Crowther's journal alone needed some 350 corrections). Always prefer a clean source; when only OCR exists, budget for it.

Shipped this push.

Three books built and merged — all with covers; the two women also received full ~1,500-word biographies and verified public-domain portraits.

Samuel Ajayi Crowther

FIRST SUB-SAHARAN AFRICAN BOOK

SHIPPED

Journal of an Expedition up the Niger (1855)

5 chapters · PR #1333 · full cover

Ochorus's **first sub-Saharan African book**. Crowther was freed from a slave ship as a boy and became the first African Anglican bishop; his 1855 expedition journal is clear first-person English.

The one cost was the source: importing it meant repairing ~350 OCR errors in the 1855 scan by hand.

Jarena Lee

SHIPPED

Religious Experience and Journal (1849)

8 chapters · PR #1359 · cover + ~1,500-word biography + verified PD portrait

The first woman authorized to preach in the AME Church, and the first African American woman to publish an autobiography. Converted under Richard Allen, who is already live on the site.

Julia A. J. Foote

SHIPPED

A Brand Plucked from the Fire (1879)

30 chapters · PR #1377 · cover + ~1,500-word biography + verified PD portrait

The first woman ordained a deacon in the AME Zion Church. With Lee and the already-live Amanda Berry Smith, the **early Black women preachers cluster** is now well represented.

ALREADY LIVE FROM PARALLEL WORK

AUTHOR	WORK	CHAPTERS
Amanda Berry Smith	<i>An Autobiography</i>	41 chapters
Richard Allen	<i>The Life, Experience, and Gospel Labours</i>	11 chapters

Together with Lee, Smith and Foote, the **early Black women preachers cluster** is now well represented — alongside Richard Allen, who converted Lee.

Nine authors with a work. Still no sermons.

AFRICAN AUTHORS WITH WORKS TODAY

AUTHOR	ORIGIN	BOOKS
Andrew Murray	South Africa	11
Athanasius of Alexandria	Egypt	2
Augustine of Hippo	North Africa	2
Samuel Ajayi Crowther	Nigeria	1
Richard Allen	African-American	1
Amanda Berry Smith	African-American	1
Jarena Lee	African-American	1
Julia A. J. Foote	African-American	1
Hannah Buyinza	Uganda	1

BIO-ONLY – NO WORKS YET

Cyprian of Carthage · Lemuel Haynes · Festo Kivengere · Simeon Nsibambi · Erica Sabiti. Kivengere, Nsibambi and Sabiti are the modern **East African Revival** figures.

KEY GAP

Zero sermons by any African author, in any language.

Zilpha Elaw — the hardest of the four.

The last of the three Black women preachers — and the one that combines both of the problems the others posed separately.

Zilpha Elaw

IN PROGRESS

Memoirs (1846)

The only public-domain source is a single **badly OCR'd Internet Archive scan** — systematic damage like “tliis”→this, plus whole garbage lines. On top of that, the memoir is a **continuous narrative with no chapter divisions**, so it needs editorial chapter-splitting.

That makes it the hardest of the four: Crowther-level OCR repair *and* the chapterization that Lee's journal required, in one book.

Status: assessment complete; decision pending on whether to push through now.

Prioritized next moves.

Ordered by leverage against the public-domain constraint — clean sources and empty shelves first.

01 Finish or defer Zilpha Elaw

IN PROGRESS

Memoirs (1846) · the last of the three Black women preachers

Completing the trio would give the diaspora a chorus, but this is the hardest of the four. The only public-domain source is a single **badly OCR'd Internet Archive scan** (systematic damage like “tliis”→this, plus whole garbage lines), and the memoir is a **continuous narrative with no chapter divisions** — it needs editorial chapter-splitting on top of Crowther-level repair.

Assessment is complete; the decision to push through now is pending. **Recommended:** decide explicitly, given the cost.

02 North African church fathers, via CCEL

RECOMMENDED

The single biggest African gap · a clean source

CCEL carries clean transcriptions, so these import fast. **Cyprian of Carthage** already has a bio but no works — start with *On the Lord's Prayer*. Then **Tertullian** (*On Prayer, To the Martyrs*), **Perpetua** (*The Passion of Perpetua and Felicity* — the earliest surviving writing by a Christian woman), **Clement of Alexandria**, **Origen** (*On Prayer*), and **Macarius of Egypt**.

Watch the translation-copyright gate: use pre-1929 translators.

03 Lemuel Haynes' sermons

RECOMMENDED

Would be Ochorus's first African-authored sermons

Haynes has a bio but no works, and Ochorus has **zero sermons by any African author, in any language**. His preaching is compact and quotable — start with his famous *Universal Salvation*.

04 East African Revival honour bios

BIO-ONLY

Pure writing — no import

Deepen **Kivengere**, **Nsibambi**, **Sabiti**, and add **Apolo Kivebulaya**, **Tiyo Soga**, and **Bernard Mizeki**. Their own writings remain in copyright, so these can only ever be bio pages — say so plainly on each.

05 More works for the Africans already here

RECOMMENDED

The import machinery and audience already exist

Crowther's episcopal *Charges* and *Experiences with Heathens and Mohammedans in West Africa*; more Augustine (*On Christian Doctrine*, *Homilies on the First Epistle of John*); and Athanasius' *Festal Letters*.

Translation, quotes, collection & reading plan

Translate African-authored works into **Swahili and Luganda** (already-live languages) via the translate-book pipeline, and grow each author's quote page.

Build an **African Voices** collection page and a reading plan — *From Carthage to Kampala* — threading Perpetua → Cyprian → Augustine → Crowther → the Revival.

6 · LESSONS & CONSTRAINTS

What the work has taught, in four lines.

Public-domain gate

Modern figures — the Revival generation — can be honoured with bio pages only; their books won't be public domain for decades.

Source cleanliness is everything

CCEL, Gutenberg and DocSouth are clean transcriptions (an import is about an hour); Internet Archive OCR is hours of hand-repair per book (Crowther ~350 fixes; Elaw comparable). Always prefer a clean source; when only OCR exists, budget for it.

Survey before building

The library moves fast — parallel sessions shipped Allen and Smith. Always check the catalog, authors.json and fixtures first; a near-duplicate of Allen was caught this way.

New author + book needs no migration

The seed creates them together. A bio-only new author, however, does need a migration.